UGOD | PhD Program

Doctor of Philosophy in Urban Governance and Design

Objectives

The PhD program seeks to train students in original research with cross-disciplinary approach to urban governance and design, and to cultivate independent and innovative thinking for knowledge creation in the field. A PhD graduate is expected to demonstrate mastery of knowledge in the chosen area of research and to synthesize and create new knowledge by making an original and substantial contribution to the cross-disciplinary studies of cities.

Focus Areas

+Transportation and Communication Infrastructure
+ Artificial Intelligence and Urban Informatics
+ Markets Population, Health and Ageing
+ Migration, Inequality, and Social Inclusion
+ Regional and Urban Economic Development
+ Smart City
+ Sustainable City
+ GIS and Spatial Analysis
+ Urban Planning and Design
+ Education, Employment and Labor

Admissions Information

Duration

Full-time: 3 years (with a relevant research master's degree),
4 years (without a relevant research master's degree)
Part-time: 6 years

Admission Requirements

Degree:

- Obtained a bachelor's degree with a proven record of outstanding performance from a recognized institution;
- or presented evidence of satisfactory work at the postgraduate level on a full-time basis for at least one year, or on a part-time basis for at least two years.

English:

Proficiency Test	Minimum Score
TOEFL-iBT	80 (one single attempt)
TOEFL-Revised paper-delivered test	60 (total scores for Reading, Listening and Writing sections)
TOEFL-pBT	550
IELTS (Academic Module)	Overall score: 6.5and All sub-score: 5.5

Tuition

¥40,000 per academic year (with PGS)

¥150,000 per academic year (for Self-funded students, including full- timeand part-time)

Postgraduate Studentship (PGS)

¥15,000 per month, up to 4 years for full-time PhD students

** Eligible full-time applicants are automatically considered for PGS without extra application.*

Curriculum

	Course List		Credits
	Minimum Credit Requirement		**21**
1	**Cross-disciplinary Core Courses**		**2**
	UCMP 6030 or UCMP 6010	Cross-disciplinary Design Thinking I or Cross-disciplinary Research Methods I	2
2	**Hub Core Courses**		**4**
	SOCH 5000	Technological Innovation and Social Entrepreneurship	2
	INFH/SYSH/FUNH 5000	Common Core course from other Hubs	2
3	**Courses on Domain Knowledge**		**Min 15**
	Required Course List		
	UGOD 5010	Science of Cities	3
	Sample Elective Course List (PhD Qualifying Exam Required Course)		
	UGOD5020	Quantitative Social Science	3
	UGOD5030	GIS and Spatial Analysis	3
	UGOD5040	Urban Data Acquisition and Analysis	3
	UGOD5060	Urban Data Analytics	3
	UGOD5101	Empirical Methods for Urban Research	3
	UGOD5112	Machine Learning in Remote Sensing	3
	UGOD5300	Introduction to GeoAI	3

**For full curriculum information : https://soch.hkust-gz.edu.cn/academics/ugod/programs/*

Program Progession for PhD

First 3-semester coursework
Demonstrate competence

↓

PhD Qualifying Exam
Written proposal with oral defense

↓

PhD candidacy

↓

Other required coursework

↓

Thesis and oral defense

↓

PhD degree conferred

Our Students

Gradute Universities/Colleges



Campus Life




Graduation Party & Movie Night




Glass-burning Activities & Outdoor Activities




Hiking Club

PhD. Program Admission

Find more details about us by scanning the QR code

Program Intro | Applicaion | Thrust Webpage | Faculty

Email: ugodt@hkust-gz.edu.cn

Address: HKUST(GZ), No.1 Duxue Road, Nansha District, Guangzhou, Guangdong, China

香港科技大学(广州)
THE HONG KONG UNIVERSITY OF SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY (GUANGZHOU)

城市治理与设计学域
URBAN GOVERNANCE AND DESIGN THRUST
社会枢纽
SOCIETY HUB

Urban Governance and Design Thrust
城市治理与设计学域



SMART CITY FOR PEOPLE

Urban Informatics / Design



PhD in Spatial Demography, State University of New York at Buffalo

Thrust Head / Professor

Ge Lin KAN

Research interests
- GIS(3D urban model)
- Spatial Epidemiology
- Data Integration
- Ageing and Urban Health
- Metaverse



PhD in GeoInformatics, Utrecht University

Professor

Bin JIANG

Research interests
- Georeferenced Big Data
- Geospatial Analysis
- AI/Deep Learning
- Sustainable Urban Design



PhD in Intelligent Transportation, University of Hong Kong

Professor

Yang YUE

Research interests
- Urban Big Data
- GeoAI
- Social Sustainability



PhD in Computer Science (Digital Technologies), University of Nottingham

Assistant Professor

Rui CAO

Research interests
- GeoAI & Spatial Data Science
- Urban Informatics & Smart Cities
- Urban Sustainability & Resilience



PhD in Computational Social Science, George Mason University

Assistant Professor

Na JIANG

Research interests
- Computational Social Science
- Urban Analytics
- Geo-simualtion
- Agent-based modeling



PhD in Regional Planning, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

Assistant Professor

Chaosu LI

Research interests
- Urban Planning for Climate Change
- Urban Form and Energy Consumption
- Urban Resilience
- Large Language Models for Urban Planning and Research



PhD in Land Economy (Urban Computing), University of Cambridge

Assistant Professor

Qiumeng LI

Research interests
- Built Environment Perception and Cognition for Mobility Behavior
- AI agent for Behavioral Geography
- Geospatial Inference
- Big Data Mining for Micro-Mobility



PhD in Urban analytics and planning, University of Twente

Assistant Professor

Cai WU

Research interests
- Urban Morphology & Urban Activities
- Human-perceived Urban Space
- AI for Urban Evaluation & Redevelopment



PhD in Remote sensing and GIS, University of Twente

Assistant Professor

Wufan ZHAO

Research interests
- AI based 3D City Modeling and Scene Understanding
- Spatio-temporal Statistical Computing
- Built Environment Analysis and Human-computer Interaction
- Smart Green Building and Urban System Resilience

Economics



PhD in Urban and Regional Economics, Massachusetts Institute of Technology

Assistant Professor

Binzhe WANG

Research interests
- Urban and Transportation Economics
- Economic Geography
- Housing and Land Development
- Human Behavior in the Built Environment



PhD in Economics, Washington University in St. Louis

Assistant Professor

Kelvin YUEN

Research interests
- Macroeconomics
- Labor Economics
- Entrepreneurship



PhD in Applied Economics and Management,Cornell University

Assistant Professor

Lin YANG

Research interests
- Environmental Economics
- Energy Transition and Climate Change
- Environmental, Urban and Transportation Policy
- High-resolution and High-frequency Data

Sociology / Demography



PhD in Social Science, The Hong Kong University of Science and Technology

Associate Professor

Zhuoni ZHANG

Research interests
- Population Migration
- Social Inequality
- Residential Segregation
- Spatial Accessibility to Public Services
- Urban Studies



PhD in Geography, University of Hong Kong

Assistant Professor

Xiaofeng LIU

Research interests
- Sustainable cities in Global South/ Belt and Road
- Environmental Governance of Urban and Regional Infrastructure
- Politics of Global Sustainable Development



PhD in Demography, Princeton University

Assistant Professor

Wanru XIONG

Research interests
- Fertility
- Marriage and Family
- Migration
- Population Projection



PhD in Sociology, University of Oxford

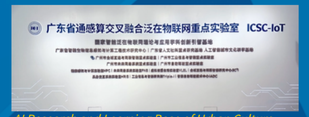
Assistant Professor

Muzhi ZHOU

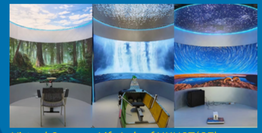
Research interests
- Family & Gender
- Cross-National Comparative Study
- Digital Technology & Digital Divide
- Time Use

Research & Achievement

- UGOD Thrust actively promotes forward-looking scientific research, committed to providing theoretical foundations for decision-making in economics, business, and governance through interdisciplinary studies. It encourages faculty to share research expertise and outcomes while translating findings into socially beneficial practical applications.
- UGOD Thrust professors have secured prestigious grants like NSFC funding, published impactful international journal papers while holding key academic leadership positions, driven cross-disciplinary innovation through government/industry collaborations on applied education projects, and received major industry research awards.



AI Research and Learning Base of Urban Culture



Virtual Campus Life Lab of HKUST(GZ)



First Prize at Digital Human Application Competition



Guangzhou Metropolitan Panel Survey



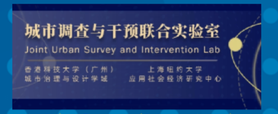
2024 IACP Rising Scholar Award



Education Practice Base (Contracted)

RUI Lab

UMEP Lab



Joint Urban Survey and Intervention Lab



LivableCity Lab

AI4DCity Lab